

Killing the NEW NO.1

India's Test team rises to the top but any dreams of dominance could be crushed by a bad calendar and the silent war between the BCCI and the ICC

| By Sharda Ugra |

With all due respect to Santa Claus, Indian cricket's pretty big gift has been wrapped and delivered well before December 25. India are now No.1 in Test cricket, only the third country after Australia and South Africa to even scale the ICC's Test rankings.

So what if some whingeing Poms are whining and some knocked-over Aussies are, well, mighty peeved. The mountain has been scaled, the view from high up is terrific and for the team's clutch of seniors, all of this implies both achievement and relief.

Just before the Indians took on South Africa in March 2008, their captain Anil Kumble talked about what awaited them over the next 18 months. Eighteen Tests, home or away against the world's five top teams—Australia, South Africa, England, New Zealand and Sri Lanka. The message was simple: train hard, play hard, win those and the No.1 is yours.

Well, now it really is. But enjoy the party while it's on, because Indian cricket is going to realise that 'tis certainly not the season to be jolly for very long. Over the next 12 months the new No.1s in the world will discover that being at the top of the mountain has actually given them too much time to think about their position and too little oxygen to make it secure.

Barring only Sri Lanka, (No.2 for four months), India are scheduled to play far fewer Tests than all other nations. (see box). While the ICC's Future

